

ART AND CULTURE



LANGUAGE AND LITERATURE

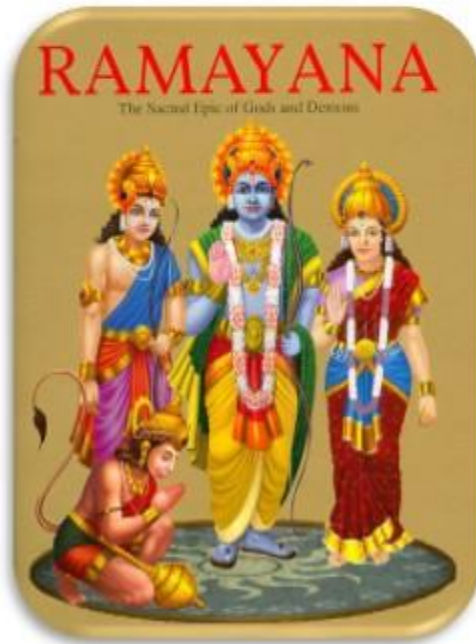
- IMPORTANT HINDU SCRIPTURES
- SANSKRIT LITERATURE

MODULE – 4



IMPORTANT HINDU SCRIPTURES

ITIHASA



- 1 The word Itihaa is derived from the three words, **Iti-Ha-Asa** implying as it happened.
- 2 The two great Indian epics, the Ramayana and the Mahabharata are texts/ scriptures falling under this category.

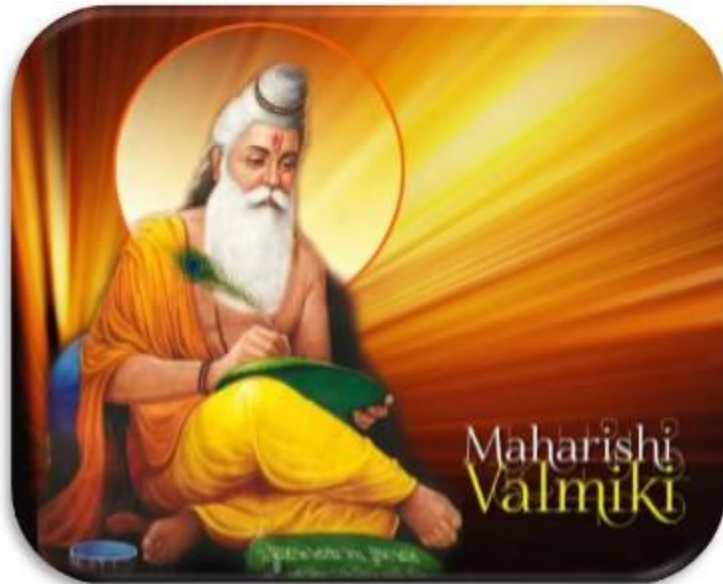
LANGUAGES

IMPORTANT HINDU SCRIPTURES

ITIHASA

1

THE RAMAYNA



1

The Ramayana is considered to be one of the holy Hindu Scriptures.

2

It gives an account of the crown prince Rama, (believed to be an incarnation of Lord Vishnu), and how he vanquishes Ravana and rescues Sita.

3

The Ramayana was written by sage Valmiki in Sanskrit verses.

4

It contains 24000 verses and is indeed a great piece of ancient literature.

LANGUAGES

IMPORTANT HINDU SCRIPTURES

ITIHASA

1

THE RAMAYNA

5 Not only does it give a historical account of the life of Rama, but also a social, cultural, and philosophical perspective where Rama represents ideal values, setting an example worth emulation.

6 In this epic, through the story of Rama who is presented as the ideal man we are instructed on how to achieve the four fold objectives (purushartha) of mankind – Dharma, Artha, Kama, Moksha.

7 There is no unanimity regarding the exact date/period in which Ramayana was written.

8 The generally agreed time frame given by historians is (1500 BC to 600 BC).

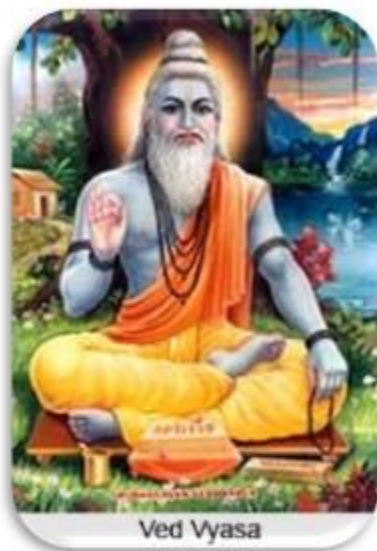
9 However, some recent researchers based on astronomic dating of events and nakshatra position described in Ramayana suggest it to be of older origin.

IMPORTANT HINDU SCRIPTURES

ITIHASA

2

THE MAHABHARATA



1 The great epic was composed by sage **Veda Vyasa** and is the longest epic (or poem) ever written.

2 Its original version is said to contain over a 1,00,000 shlokas (longer version) while the shorter version comprises 24000 shlokas.

3 The story recounts the **fratricidal war between the Kauravas and the Pandavas** which involves all of the remaining dynasties and kingdoms of the time.

4 The **Sutradhar of story is Lord Krishna**. It gives an account of the political, social and cultural life.

5 Further, it is also a **treatise on philosophy and metaphysics** as seen from several chapters/ portions of the book, particularly the Bhagavad Gita.

LANGUAGES

IMPORTANT HINDU SCRIPTURES

ITIHASA

3

THE BHAGAVAD GITA



1

The Bhagavad Gita is considered to be the holiest of the Hindu scriptures.

2

Although it is a part of the Mahabharata, owing to its philosophical and spiritual importance, it is considered as a separate and a standalone scriptures.

3

The Gita is a discourse by Lord Krishna to Arjuna given on the battlefield of Kurukshetra, when Arjuna becomes despondent at the prospect of engaging in a war with his cousins, gurus, and dear ones.

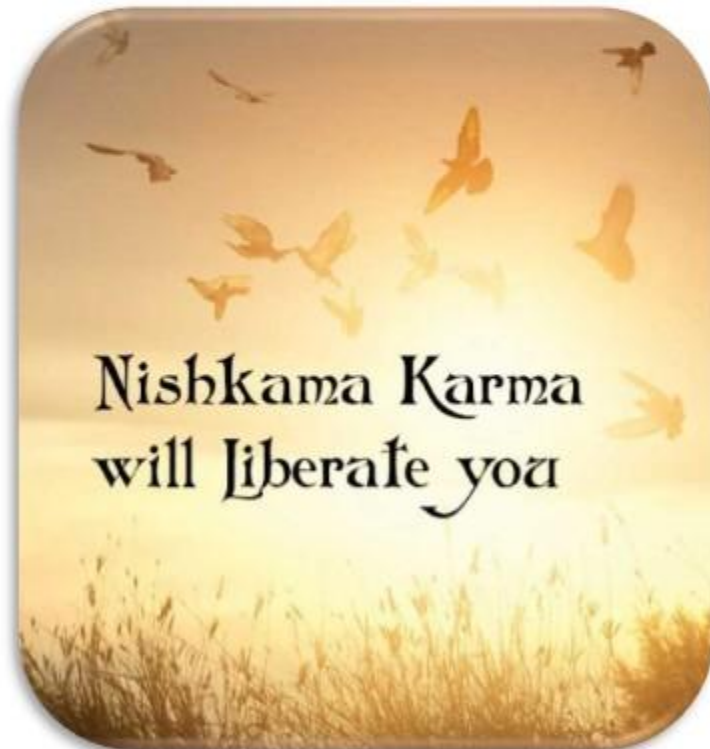
LANGUAGES

IMPORTANT HINDU SCRIPTURES

ITIHASA

3

THE BHAGAVAD GITA



4 The scriptures is a treatise on topics such as **Dharma** (duty), **Karma** Yoga, **Bhakti** Yoga, and **Jnan** Yoga.

5 It heavily draws upon the **Samkhya** and **Yoga** philosophy.

6 It further enunciates the philosophy of '**Nishkam Karma**' (detached performance of one's duties).

LANGUAGES

IMPORTANT HINDU SCRIPTURES

ITIHASA

4

PURANAS

1 The word Purana literally means, old, or ancient or historical.

2 These are **ancient Indian mythological texts**, which consist of the **narrative stories about the creation of the universe and illustrate its history till the supposed destruction of the universe.**

3 It contains the stories of the kings, heroes, sages, and demigods, but it **focuses on the divine Hindu trimurti or trinity/ three Gods: Brahma, Vishnu and Mahesh.**

4 There are **18 major Puranas (Mahapuranas)** and each gives prominence to a particular deity and expound on the philosophical and religious concepts related to them.

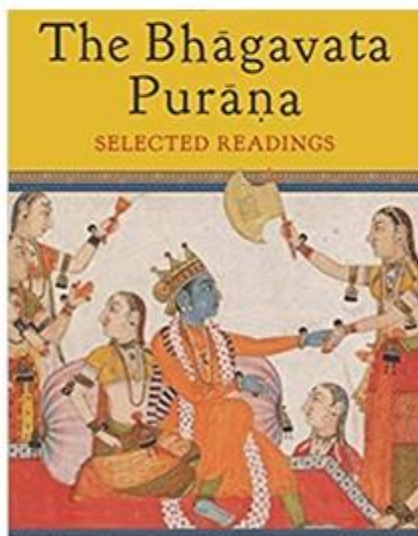
IMPORTANT HINDU SCRIPTURES

ITIHASA

4

PURANAS

- 5 Some of the more prominent and well-known Puranas are, **Brahma, Vayu, Agni, Garuda, Bhagavata Padma, Vishnu and Matsya.**



- 6 These contain **anecdotes about the social, cultural and religious life of post-Vedic India** and provide the historians with critical information about the geography, history and the dynastic genealogies.

- 7 **Sage Veda Vyasa** is credited with the compilation of the Puranas which are 18 in number.

- 8 The **Bhagavada Purana** is the most studied and popular of the Puranas.

IMPORTANT HINDU SCRIPTURES

ITIHASA

4

PURANAS



9

It describes the **avatars of lord Vishnu**.

10

It also forms the **basis of Gaudiya Vaishnavism** founded by medieval saint in Bengal, **Chaitanya Mahaprabhu**.

11

Other important Puranas are Brahma-Purana, Vishnu-Purana, Shiva-Purana, and Markendaya-Purana.

12

The **Puranas and the Itihasa** were the **religious literature** which was more **popular** in the masses/common people as the study of the Vedas was more restricted to the Brahmanical section of the society.

LANGUAGES

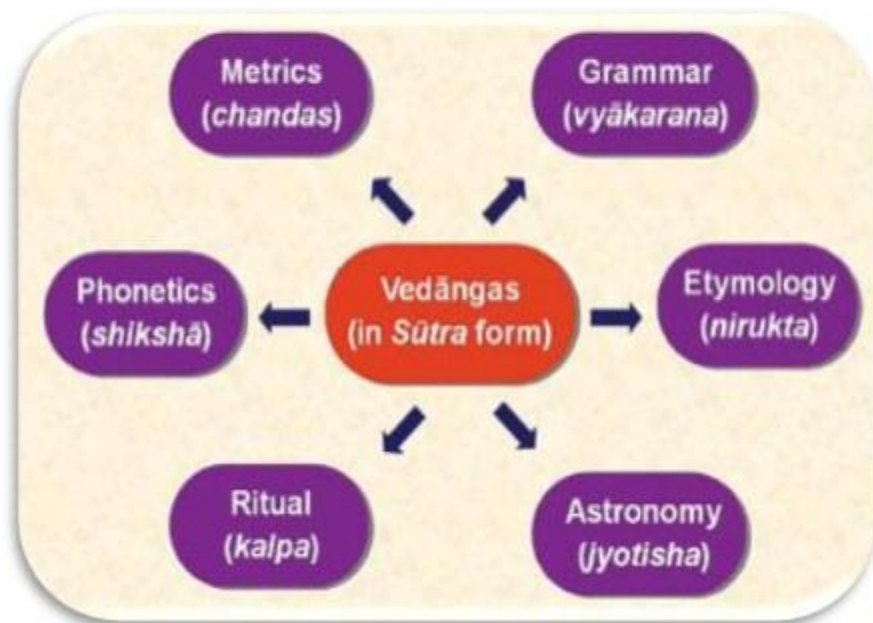
OTHER HINDU SCRIPTURES

VEDANGS AND UPVEDAS

Although strictly not a part of the Vedas, the **Vedāngas** (literally meaning 'part of the Vedas') and **Upavedas** (literally meaning 'subsidiary or sub-Veda') are considered to be **auxiliary disciplines** associated with the study of the Vedas.

1

VEDANGAS



1

These are six separate disciplines which aid in the study of the Vedas or are independent subjects in themselves. They are:

- Nirukta
- Vyakarana
- Kalpa
- Shiksha
- Chandas
- Jyotisha

LANGUAGES

OTHER HINDU SCRIPTURES

VEDANGS AND UPVEDAS

1

VEDANGAS

2 These are :

- a) **Nirukta** – dealing with etymology; **study of obscure phrases and origin of words**. This discipline provides explanation of words especially some ancient words with unclear meaning.
- b) **Vyakaran** – **Study of grammar**. This discipline focuses on the rules of grammar and linguistic analysis to establish the exact form of words and sentences to properly express ideas.
- c) **Kalpa** – **dealing with religious ceremonies**. This discipline focuses on standardizing procedures for Vedic rituals associated with major life events such as birth, wedding and death in family, as well as discussing the personal conduct and proper duties of an individual in different stages of his life.
- d) **Shiksha** – **study of phonetics and pronunciation**. This discipline focuses on the letters of the Sanskrit alphabet, accent, stress, melody and rules of euphonic (pleasing to the ear) combination of words during a Vedic recitation.
- e) **Chandas** – **study of verses and prosody**. This discipline focuses on the poetic meters.
- f) **Jyotisha** – **study of movement of celestial bodies and astronomy**. This discipline focuses on auspicious time for rituals.

LANGUAGES

OTHER HINDU SCRIPTURES

VEDANGS AND UPVEDAS

2

UPAVEDAS



1

There are **five recognized Upvedas** each dealing with a separate discipline.

2

These are:

- a) **Arthaveda** – Dealing with science of sociology, economics, and political systems.
- b) **Dhanurveda** – science of defence, arms, and armament.
- c) **Gandharvavedha** – science of music and dance (includes singing and instruments).
- d) **Ayurveda** – science of medicines.
- e) **Sthapathyaveda** – science of architecture.

LANGUAGES

OTHER HINDU SCRIPTURES

DHARMA SHASTRA



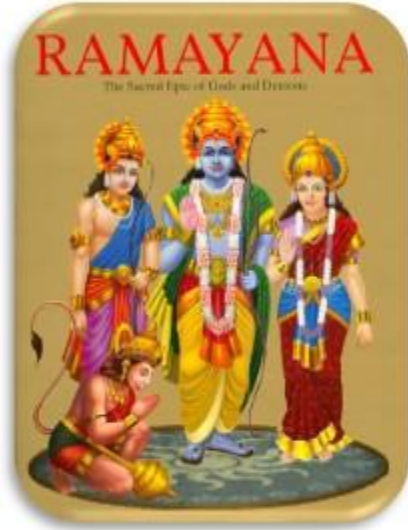
- 1 These were texts which prescribed laws and religious duties pertaining to righteous conduct in the society.

- 2 They are reflective of the religious and social conditions of the ancient society.

- 3 Dharma shastras dwell on issues like the '**Aachara**' (rules of daily rituals), '**Vyavahara**' (legal procedure; rules of substantive law and removal of doubts), '**Prayaschitta**' (rules of penance), etc.

- 4 The important Dharma shastras are Manu-Smriti, Yajnavalkya-Smriti, Narada-Smriti, and Vishnu-Smriti.

CLASSICAL SANSKRIT LITERATURE



- 1 Most of the literature in Sanskrit has been divided into the **Vedic** and the **Classical** categories.

- 2 The **two epics: Mahabharata and Ramayana** are also part of the **classical category** but are discussed separately because of their religious importance.
- 3 Irrespective of their centrality to the Hindu religion, these epics can also be considered to be the pre-cursors of Sanskrit **Kavya** (epic poetry), **nataka** (classical drama) and other treatises on medicine, statecraft, grammar, astronomy, mathematics, etc.
- 4 Most of this Sanskrit literature was bound by the rules of grammar that have been explained brilliantly in **Panini's Ashtadhyayi**, a treatise on the rigid rules which bind the Sanskrit language.

LANGUAGES

SANSKRIT DRAMA



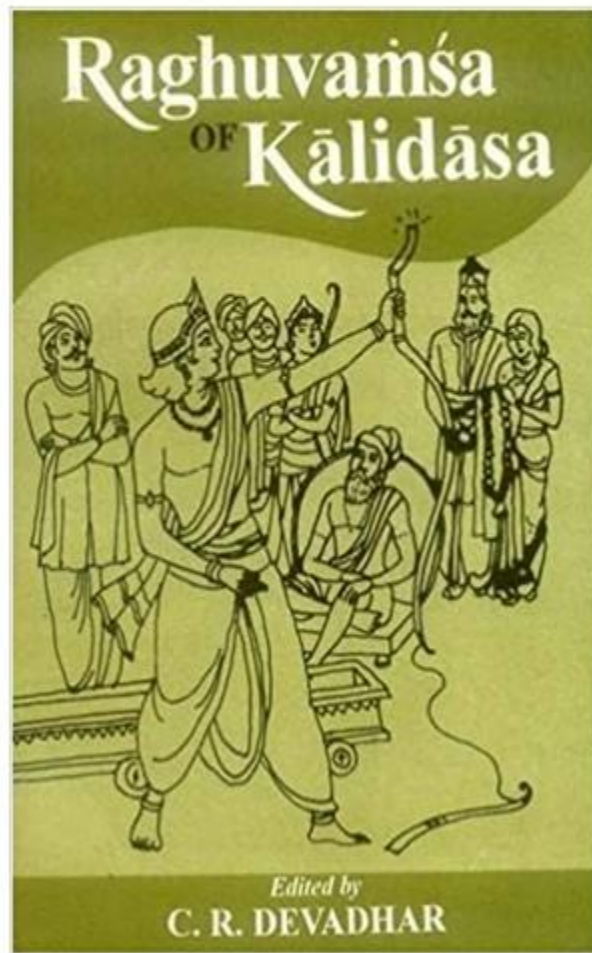
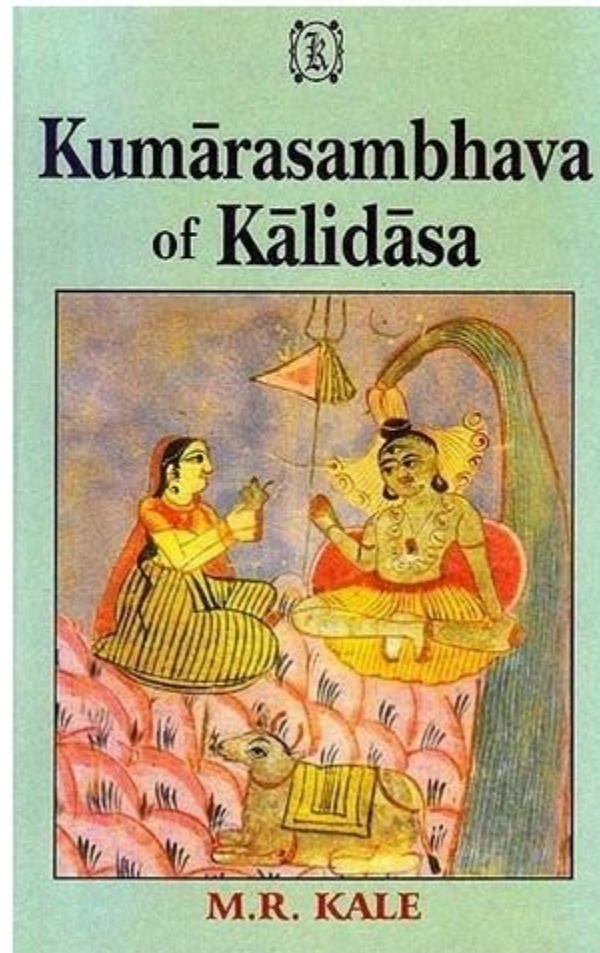
- 1 One of the most popular genres of lyric poetry and prose is the popular romantic tales whose sole purpose was to **entertain the public or Lokaranjana**.
- 2 These were usually **written in the form of stories** and yet they gave a unique perspective on life.
- 3 These were usually written in the form of **elaborate dramas**.
- 4 The rules regarding the performance, acting, gestures, stage direction and acting have been illustrated in the **Natyasastra by Bharata** (1 BC–1 AD).

LANGUAGES

SANSKRIT DRAMA

Major dramas written in this period are:

KALIDASA	• Malavikagnimitra (the love story of Malavika and Agnimitra) • Vikramorvasiya (Love story of Vikram and Urvasi) • Abhigyan Shakuntala (the recollection of Shakuntala)
SUDRAKA	Mricchakatika (The Little Clay Cart) Love affair of young brahmin Charudatta with a wealthy courtesan.
VISHAKHDUTTA	• Mudra Rakshasa (is a political drama and narrates ascent of king Chandragupta Maurya to power in India). • Devi Chandraguptam
BHAVABHUTI	Uttara Ramacharitam (the later life of Rama, the abandonment of Sita and their reunion).
BHASA	Swapnavasavadatta (Vasavadatta in dream), Pancharatra (the five nights), Urubhanga (broken thigh- the story of Duryodhana during and after his fight with Bhima).



- 1 This genre is also called Kavya or poetry. Unlike the drama section where the story is the main focus of the text, poetry concentrates more on the form, style, figure of speech, etc.
- 2 One of the greatest Sanskrit poets is Kalidasa who wrote Kumara Sambhava (the birth of Kumar), and Raghuvamsa (the dynasty of the Raghus).
- 3 He also wrote two khandakavyas (smaller poems) called Meghaduta (the cloud messenger) and Ritusamhara (medley of seasons).

LANGUAGES

SANSKRIT POETRY



4 One should not forget to mention the contribution of poets like **Harisena** who wrote during the Gupta period.

5 He wrote several poems in praise of valour of **Samudra Gupta** and it was so well appreciated that it was inscribed on the **Allahabad pillar**.

6 Another extremely popular Sanskrit poet was **Jayadeva** who wrote **Gita Govinda** in the 12th century.

7 It concentrates on the life and escapades of Lord Krishna. The text combines **elements of devotion to Lord Krishna, his love for Radha and the beauty of nature**.

Other major poets are:

BHARAVI (550 A.D.)	MAGHA (65-700 A.D.)
Kiratarjuniyam (Kirat and Arjun)	Sishupalavadha (the killing of Shishupal)

OTHER MAJOR SANSKRIT TEXTS

**WHAT ARE SMRITIS AND SRUTIS?**

Smritis and Srutis are vedic literature.

Smriti, literally means "that which is remembered" are a body of Hindu texts usually attributed to an author, traditionally written down. In contrast, Śrutis are considered authorless, gets transmitted verbally across the generations.

- 1 There were several books written about the sciences and state governance in Sanskrit for the benefit of the learned men.
- 2 Historians argue that between 500 and 200 BC, several major books on law were written and compiled, which are called the Dharmasutras.
- 3 These were compiled alongside the smritis that are known as Dharmashastras.
- 4 These are the basis of the laws governing the subjects of most Hindu kingdoms.

OTHER MAJOR SANSKRIT TEXTS

MANUSMṚITI

(Text with Sanskrit Commentary and English Translation)

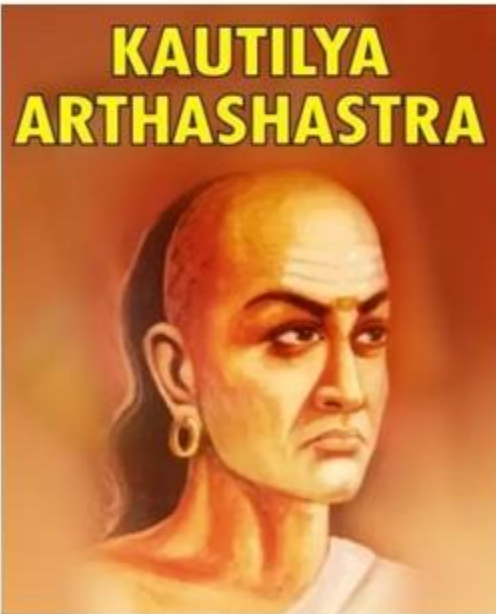


DID YOU KNOW?

It was one of the first Sanskrit texts to have been translated into English in 1776, by Sir William Jones, and was used to formulate the Hindu law by the British colonial government

- 5 These not only elucidate the rules according to which property could be held, sold or transferred but also elaborated on the punishments for offences ranging from fraud to murder.
- 6 Another major text is Manusmriti (laws of Manu), which defines the role of man and woman in a society, their interaction at a social plane and the code of conduct that they were supposed to follow.
- 7 The text is written as a discourse given by Manu, the ancestor of mankind.
- 8 The Manusmriti might have been written and compiled during 200 BC and 200 AD.

OTHER MAJOR SANSKRIT TEXTS



- 9 One of the most famous texts about **statecraft** from the Mauryan period is **Kautilya's Arthashastra**.

- 10 It concentrates on the **economic and social conditions** of the Mauryan empire.
- 11 Due focus was given to the **military strategy** which should be employed by the state.
- 12 The text mentions that '**Kautilya**' or '**Vishnugupta**' wrote it.
- 13 Historians argue that both these names were an **alias** for **Chanakya** who was a learned scholar at the court of Emperor Chandragupta Maurya.

OTHER MAJOR SANSKRIT TEXTS

- 14** While Sanskrit was the preferred language of the courts in ancient period, it **got an impetus in the Gupta period**, who employed many great poets, dramatists and scholars of various subjects.
- 15** In this period Sanskrit became the preferred language of communication of cultured and educated people.
- 16** In the later **Kushana period**, several major Sanskrit scholars received patronage.
- 17** For example, **Ashvagoshā** wrote **Buddhacharita**, which elucidates the biography of Buddha.
- 18** He also composed several poetic works and **Saundarananda** is one of the best examples of his poems.
- 19** Although literature in Sanskrit was **not as predominant in the medieval period**, some excellent works were composed in Rajasthan and Kashmir.
- 20** Two of the most notable works from medieval Kashmir are **Kalhan's Rajatarangini** which gives a detailed account of the kings of Kashmir and **Somadeva's Kathasarit-sagar** which is a poetic work.

OTHER MAJOR SANSKRIT TEXTS

Some of the scientific texts written in this period are:

CHARAK	Charak Samhita (Book on Medicine)
SUSHRUTA	Sushruta Samhita (Book on surgery)
MADHAVA	Madhava Nidana (Book on pathology)
VARAMIHIRA	• Pancha-Siddhantika (Book on astrology) • Brihat Samhita (book on wide ranging subjects like planetary movements, geology, architecture, etc)
ARYABHATTA	Aryabhatiya (Book on astronomy and mathematics)
PINGALA	Book on Mathematics
BHASKARA	Siddhanta Shiromani

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